

As world attention refocuses, again, toward Iraq, informed experts/specialists, including some with direct, in-depth experience in the Kurdistan Region, offer their ideas of what will happen, or needs to happen, next.

Below are brief thoughts from 7 experts/specialists including Aliza Marcus and Emma Sky, and Juan Cole who publishes his well-read blog 'Informed Comment'.

With no Nelson Mandela and Desmond Tutu anywhere on the horizon to begin a critically important national reconciliation process to bring the country together, the ultimate penultimate next step is rather obvious: real federalism where each part shares power and governs its own affairs, including (especially) security, and embarks on efforts to learn and live with other fellow parts in peace and prosperity.

Amazingly, seemingly unaware of the many successful examples of federalism all around the world, too many Iraqis (and others) interpret and believe federalism is about splitting a country apart instead of a means to bind it together.

Under current circumstances, macro doesn't work. How much more convincing does it have to be?

It's about micro over macro. At the macro level, each part, will be free of excessively centralized authoritarian rule that destructively promotes one major group over all other groups. At the micro level, each part will have its own internal divisions to constructively deal with. They can do it, as proven in some places in Iraq, most notably in the Kurdistan Region.

Given the operational environment in Iraq is much more verbal-visual than writing-reading, for one thing, at the micro level, there is much more motivation and opportunity for progressive communication.

If the ultimate penultimate doesn't work, then there's always the ultimate ultimate that could very well, over time, be the most effective solution of all. Looking ahead, especially under current circumstances, what are the possible unintended circumstances that say otherwise?

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How to Stabilize Iraq and Stop the March of ISIS

INTRODUCTION

Conflicts in Syria and Iraq have converged into a widening regional crisis spearheaded by a powerful extremist group, the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria. Sunni militants have mounted their boldest offensive in Iraq since the departure of American troops at the end of 2011, driving the military forces from territory north and west of Baghdad and taking the cities of Mosul and Tikrit with little resistance.

What can be done to stabilize Iraq and stop the march of extremist groups? What should the United States do to follow up on its military and economic commitments in the country?

Juan Cole

An Inclusive Leader for All Iraqis

Juan Cole is the Richard P. Mitchell collegiate professor of history at the University of Michigan. His most recent book is "The New Arabs: How the Millennial Generation is Changing the Middle East."

The crisis in Iraq is not limited to the successes on the battlefield of the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria. Rather, the Sunni west and north of the country appear to have risen up against the largely Shiite army and central government, tired of the humiliations heaped on them since the American invasion of 2003.

In 2006-2007, Sunnis were ethnically cleansed from Baghdad. Sunnis boycotted the first elections of 2005, angered over the U.S. reduction of Falluja. They rejected the Constitution that that Parliament fashioned in their absence. They participated in subsequent elections but were consistently marginalized by the majority Shiites and the Kurds. Sunnis often viewed the government of Prime Minister Nouri al-Maliki, leader of the Shiite fundamentalist Da'wa party, as a puppet of Shiite Iran.

Iraq needs a major political reform that works against a tyranny of the Shiite majority. It also needs a system that encourages political alliances across religious and ethnic divisions. Because the roots of the crisis are political, military intervention alone cannot resolve it. Restitution should be made to Sunnis who lost everything in the civil war of 2006 and 2007. More, Iraq needs a new prime minister, one willing to be inclusive of the Sunni-Arab population.

Of course, ISIS is an extremely nasty group that needs to be defeated. It is allegedly funded by wealthy Salafi fundamentalist businessmen in Kuwait and elsewhere in the Gulf, and the U.S. Treasury Department should sanction them and make it difficult to transfer money to it. The U.S. should also work with Saudi Arabia and Iran in an attempt to resolve their differences, since the wars in Syria and Iraq are in part proxy wars between these two regional powers.

Kiron K. Skinner

Honor the Sacrifice of Our Troops

Kiron K. Skinner is the director of the Center for International Relations and Politics at Carnegie Mellon University and a research fellow at Stanford University's Hoover Institution. She is a co-author of "Strategy of Campaigning: Lessons From Ronald Reagan and Boris Yeltsin."

According to the Obama Doctrine, making a lighter footprint around the world and ending the wars inherited from President George W. Bush will improve U.S. global standing and encourage other states to take greater responsibility for their own peace, security, political liberalization and prosperity. That doctrine was put to the test last week as the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria, an Al Qaeda offshoot, routed the Iraqi security forces in Mosul and then in other towns.

At the beginning of his presidency, Obama pledged, "We'll begin to responsibly leave Iraq to its people." Reaffirming this position later in a speech to the troops, he said the war was

over because "we sent our troops to Iraq to do away with Saddam Hussein's regime, and you got the job done."

"We kept our troops in Iraq to help establish a sovereign government," the president noted, and Americans and coalition partners shed blood to help create an intact country that would not require their continued presence. But at least since parts of Falluja fell to ISIS six months ago, Iraq has been headed toward civil war. This past week's victories give ISIS control over more territory than Al Qaeda ever had anywhere.

Ending the war in Iraq is at the core of the Obama Doctrine — but wars don't end just because the United States withdraws. That reality is becoming clearer by the day, and that's why the president called for a strategic review of his options this past week. A more refined doctrine may emerge from that review, and it may call for airstrikes or drone support of the Maliki government — in defense of the sovereignty President Obama said justified the withdrawal of American combat troops from Iraq in the first place.

Haleh Esfandiari

If Shrines Are Threatened, Iran Will Send Troops

Haleh Esfandiari is the director of the Middle East program at the Woodrow Wilson International Center for Scholars.

Iran will need to be involved in any international solution to the chaos that has overtaken Iraq. But while there may be some commanders of the Revolutionary Guards who are arguing to send in military forces, Iran is unlikely to do more than send advisers to assist the Iraqi military, without committing its own forces.

Iran will probably be very cautious about becoming involved in another country's civil war. The financial drain would undermine already shaky budgets and an invasion would further strain relations with Persian Gulf states. The involvement in Syria is already a source of murmurs of discontent regarding costs and resources that might be better used at home.

If the holy Shiite shrines in Karbala and Najaf are threatened, though, that would be seen as a religious threat and the Iranian government would send troops.

Still, the government will find it very difficult to justify having its military help the discredited Maliki government and the Iraqi army. The memory of the Iran-Iraq war, when Iraq invaded Iran and over 250,000 Iranians lost their lives, is still very vivid in people's mind. The generation that fought in that war, from 1980 to 1987, is still very much present. The martyrs of that war are commemorated on every official occasion; and the government would find it difficult to justify body bags coming home again simply to defend a government so unworthy of support.

Aliza Marcus

The U.S. Must Listen to Iraqi Kurds

Aliza Marcus is the author of "Blood and Belief: The P.K.K. and the Kurdish Fight for Independence."

Iraqi Kurdish strategy has paid off. The Kurds spent the past few years working to strengthen the Kurdistan region while keeping a wary distance from the rest of Iraq. They didn't trust Baghdad, neither to deal with them fairly, nor to survive as a secular, democratic state. The Iraqi Kurds were proved right. Baghdad consistently tried to weaken the Kurdistan Regional Government through fights over oil money and deals – and now the Iraqi state itself is under threat from the radical Islamist ISIS. The Kurds are in a strong position precisely because they ignored United States pressure to accommodate Baghdad.

That's why the Washington approach of putting the Kurds second should finally end. The U.S. should recognize the importance of the Kurds to a stable Middle East.

It's not just Kurdish strategy that's paying off in Iraq. So is Kurdish pragmatism and a sense of unity, no matter how fractured at times. Just last month the Kurdistan Regional Government was digging ditches to block off Syria's Kurdish region from Iraqi Kurdistan. The president of Iraqi Kurdistan, Massoud Barzani, was angry that the Kurdish Democratic Union Party (P.Y.D.), the dominant player in the Syrian Kurdish areas, wouldn't share power with his allied parties in Syria. Barzani also didn't trust the P.Y.D. because of its connections to the main Kurdish party in Turkey, the P.K.K., with which he has fought over the years. Now Barzani has reopened the border and the P.Y.D. has said it will defend Iraqi Kurdistan if necessary. These are not empty words — the P.Y.D. has been battling ISIS and other Islamic radical groups inside Syria for over a year.

The ISIS offensive in Iraq has so far bypassed Kurdistan, but there's no telling what the Islamist radical fighters would do if they secure their hold over the northwestern part of the country. Nor is it clear that the region's states are going to welcome the surviving Kurdish region, especially with the newfound Kurdish unity.

The U.S. has never had an independent Kurdish policy. Instead, it's always indexed its approach to the desires of states in the region. The U.S. has refused to engage seriously with Turkish Kurds because of Turkish opposition to Kurdish rights within its own border. U.S. support for Syrian rebels blinded it to the importance of Syria's Kurds and their willingness to stand up to Islamist fighters. Washington's insistence on propping up Maliki and opposing Kurdish moves to strengthen their own region didn't pay off.

Ramzi Mardini

U.S. Military Can't Fix This

Ramzy Mardini is a nonresident fellow at the Atlantic Council based in Amman, Jordan.

The bold Sunni militant offensive is the latest inflection point in the long-term unraveling of post-Saddam Iraq. Nevertheless, despite all the international concern it has produced, Iraq's revived insurgency isn't a problem with a clear and corresponding solution. Indeed, while President Obama says "I don't rule out anything," Washington is in no position to change facts on the ground and alter the conditions that are driving the country's renewed insurgency.

The reality is that violence and asymmetric warfare will remain a symptom of the new Iraq for the foreseeable future. This isn't due to an alleged shortage of military capabilities, but rather a reflection of what Iraq essentially is: an unreconciled, broken state, plagued by

deep ethno-sectarian cleavages, weak institutions and a political system prone to relapse toward an authoritarian order.

The Obama administration has placed counterterrorism at the forefront of its foreign policy toward the Middle East. Unfortunately, far too much emphasis has been placed on hard power as the primary prescription to combat terrorism in the region. Indeed, it was the U.S. invasion and occupation that unleashed the problem of Sunni and Shiite militancy in Iraq. Thus, any U.S. approach against terrorism that is defined by military power ends up misdiagnosing the problem: insurgencies and terrorism are not causally derived from an absence of security; they are rather manifested from deep social, political and economic ills.

Armed intervention by external actors into ongoing conflicts in the Middle East will likely add fuel to the fire. In combating the increase of violence in Iraq, Washington and Baghdad have expanded a security-centric partnership. But Iraq is not a democratic, representative state; nor does its government behave as a central and credible arbiter between factions.

Instead, Iraq is becoming ruled by a regime, which behaves as a political organism whose core purpose is to survive and thrive at the expense of other political factions.

The rise of violence in Iraq is due to a confluence of centrifugal dynamics – internal and external – that have built up during and after the U.S. invasion and occupation. Neither the civil war in neighboring Syria, nor the belligerent and authoritarian behavior of Iraq's prime minister can solely explain the resurgence of Sunni and Shiite militancy, the failure of the political system or the shortfalls of Iraq's million-man security apparatus.

To effectively contain the militant threat spilling over from Syria will require the cooperation of various parts of the state and society in Iraq — from national, provincial and local to political, religious and tribal. But how can the U.S. fix a problem in which it has a fraction of a fraction of influencing the solution? For example, to stabilize Iraq will require stabilizing Syria; to stabilize Syria will require a regional settlement, among other things. The United States cannot force the Iraqis to come to terms with one another and cooperate. Washington is often perceived as supporting one political faction over another, especially through security-assistance to the regime.

The Iraq war exposed the limitations of translating hard military power to political influence on the ground. Unfortunately, that same thinking persists in Washington. A military response to a political problem tends to conflate the problem, while compounding its complexity. The White House would be wise to tread softly on the usage of military power in Iraq, and pursue financial incentives for Sunni tribal leaders to cooperate and coordinate against a threat in their own backyard.

Emma Sky

A Regional Diplomatic Response

Emma Sky is a senior fellow at Yale University's Jackson Institute for Global Affairs. She served in Iraq from 2003 to 2004 as the Governorate Coordinator of Kirkuk, and from 2007 to 2010 as a political adviser to Gen. Raymond Odierno, who was the commanding general of U.S. forces in Iraq.

Washington needs to stop viewing Iraq separately from the crises in Syria and Lebanon. The region has become one big battlefield. And what is happening there affects not only the Middle East but also Europe and the U.S.

Iraqi security forces outnumber the militants of the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria by 100 to 1 – and they are better equipped. Yet, the Iraqi forces are crumbling in the wake of the ISIS assaults. This is because the Iraqi army suffers from poor morale, weak leadership and heavy politicization. With no national unity at the political level, the military lacks the will to stand together to counter the attacks.

Shiite militias are once more remobilizing, with the risk of a return to all out sectarian civil war. Previously, the Sunni Awakening Councils kept Al Qaeda in Iraq – the forerunner of ISIS – at bay. However, Sunni tribal leaders have been targeted and undermined by the Shiite prime minister, Nuri Kamal al-Maliki, pushing them to a position of neutrality and sometimes support for the insurgents. But these Sunni leaders are key to bringing back stability in Iraq.

The U.S. and Europe have a stake in what happens in Iraq. The crisis in the region is drawing in Western-born Muslims and radicalizing them. There needs to be a realistic understanding of who our friends are – a new broad-based Iraqi government, the Kurdistan regional government and Sunni tribes – to bolster them in their fight against ISIS.

In terms of the way ahead, a military cordon is required immediately to stop the advance on Baghdad, and to prevent takeover of the Taji military depot. This requires deployment of effective Iraqi military units.

A transitional unity government should be formed with the backing of Iran and Turkey, and guaranteed by the United States. This transitional unity government should approve a minister of defense and a minister of the interior, and consider airstrikes.

Serious international diplomacy is required, along with real security negotiations that engage all regional players, including Iran. An international conference, perhaps under U.N. auspices, could look at the situation in Syria, Iraq and Lebanon together: how to stop the bloodshed, provide humanitarian assistance and establish new governance arrangements.

Once the security situation in Iraq is brought under control, a new government should be formed out of an agreement among Iraq's elites. It is highly unlikely that Maliki will be able to negotiate such an agreement given his conduct over the last few years, his unwillingness to compromise and his targeting of his political rivals. He should be offered assurances of nonprosecution in return for giving up power peacefully. The choice for Iraqis cannot simply be Maliki or ISIS. It is this dichotomy that is driving Iraq to disaster.

Michael Knights

Unity With Kurdistan Will Stave Off the Threat

Michael Knights is a Boston-based Lafer fellow of The Washington Institute, specializing in the military and security affairs of Iraq, Iran, and the Persian Gulf states.

The scale of Iraq's military collapse is of historic proportions. Of nearly 250 combat battalions in the Iraqi army and federal police, almost 70 cannot be accounted for. Some will reform, but most have lost practically all of their vehicles and equipment. A quarter of Iraq's

forces are now out of the game for months at least. How can this loss be overcome in time to break the momentum of ISIS?

One option may be U.S. military strikes, but a complementary initiative is to bring the Iraqi Kurds fully into the war against ISIS. The Kurds possess the only intact armed forces capable of providing resistance to ISIS in northern Iraq, but they are girding their forces because of a bitter struggle with Baghdad over revenue-sharing and oil exports.

The geometry of the battlefield makes the Kurds particularly vital: ISIS pursued Iraq's retreating forces south of Mosul for over 200 miles, with most units ordered to rally on Taji in Baghdad's northern suburbs. This has given ISIS significant depth on the north-south axis, meaning that the government may need to painstakingly retake a sequence of key insurgent-held cities in turn. But due to the Kurds' advanced positions all along ISIS' eastern flank, the jihadist movement has very little west-east strategic depth if key centres like Mosul were counterattacked from the Kurdish-held areas. Kurdistan has offered the use of its airbases to U.S. forces many times, and they would be an ideal place from which to conduct limited U.S. airstrikes. This was precisely the formula – U.S. special forces advisers and pesh mergas – that crumbled Saddam's hold on Mosul and northern Iraq in a matter of days in 2003.

The Iraqi Kurds are generous and brave: they hate the extremism of radical jihadist groups and will not tolerate a major jihadist center in Mosul, located just an hour's drive east of the shining new skyscrapers of Erbil, the Kurdish capital. Indeed social media reporting of Kurdish martyrs in the fight against ISIS are proliferating. The Kurdish pesh mergas are already fighting ISIS at half a dozen points from the Syrian border to Iran, with Baghdad's air forces in support in some areas.

How can the Kurds be convinced to go beyond these limited actions and bring their 80-plus battalions fully into the counter-offensive? Simple: Baghdad has been withholding Iraqi Kurdistan's budget since the start of 2014 in a dispute over the details of oil exports, an important issue but one that now seems petty in light of the current crisis. So job one for the United States is to keep up the pressure on Baghdad to pay the Kurds what they are owed by Baghdad, and to shelve disputes about oil and revenue issues until the threat from ISIS has been overthrown.
